

Resources for Saving Money

There are many resources in your community that can help you save you money and assist with:

- Utilities
- Emergency rental assistance
- Food
- Household supplies
- Clothing
- Transportation costs
- Medical care and/or costs
- Prescription medications
- Dental services
- Computer equipment
- Internet access
- Furniture

Federal & State Resources:

Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP): The national food assistance program (formerly called Food Stamps). Money is deposited directly into your account and you can use your SNAP card at stores or farmers markets like a debit or credit card. Many Americans qualify for SNAP benefits and can receive \$200+ a month for groceries (significantly more if you have dependents in your household to care for). If you are a resident of Oregon, you can apply for SNAP, medical, cash, or childcare benefits here: <https://one.oregon.gov/>

Social Security Benefits: Social Security is the retirement plan for nearly all working Americans. The Social Security Administration offers Social Security Disability Insurance (SSDI) and Supplemental Security Income (SSI) for people with disabilities, including mental health conditions. Apply for SSDI and SSI online at <https://secure.ssa.gov/iClaim/rib> or by phone.

Medicare & Medicaid: Medicare is the federal health insurance program in the United States that is generally for people 65 years of age or older or individuals with a qualifying medical condition or disability. Medicaid is the state health insurance program that helps pay the costs of healthcare for low-income individuals and families. **The Oregon Health Plan** is Oregon's Medicaid program. You can apply for free or reduced health coverage here: <https://www.oregon.gov/oha/hsd/ohp/pages/apply.aspx>

Free or Reduced Clinics: Most cities and towns have free or income-based healthcare clinics, including for emergency care, doctor's visits, and dentist appointments. To find a free or reduced clinic in your area, visit <https://www.freeclinics.com/>

Individual Development Accounts (IDAs): Special asset-building savings accounts that match the deposits of low-income individuals or families to help them save for higher education, job training, home ownership, etc. IDAs are discussed further in Workshop Ten.

Reduced Public Transit Passes: Many public transit systems have reduced fare options for low-income riders. For example, in Portland, you can apply online for an Honored Citizen Hop Card, which will reduce your bus or train fees. To apply, visit: <https://trimet.org/lowincome/index.htm>

Medication Assistance: Pharmaceutical companies offer medication scholarships for low-income individuals. PhRMA has a service called the Partnership for Prescription Assistance that will link you with the maker of your drug. Go to <http://www.PPARX.org> for access to more than 475 different assistance programs. The site is easy to use and is a great starting point, however be cautious of other sites that charge fees for their services.

VA Benefits: Veterans may be eligible for a number of benefits including physical and mental health care; disability compensation; tuition assistance for college, graduate school or other training programs; educational and career counseling; job training; housing assistance/loan programs; a pension program; and life insurance. Visit the U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs at <https://www.va.gov/> for more information, eligibility requirements, and to apply for benefits.

Reduced Internet: If you are eligible for public assistance programs like SNAP, SSI, Medicaid, Housing Assistance, and the National School Lunch program, you may qualify for Internet Essentials from Comcast. Internet Essentials benefits include high-speed internet service for just \$9.95/month, no activation or equipment rental fees, access to Xfinity Wi-Fi hotspots, the option to purchase a computer for \$149.99, and more. To check eligibility requirements and to apply online, visit: <https://www.xfinity.com/support/articles/comcast-broadband-opportunity-program>

Weatherization Assistance Program (WAP): The U.S. Department of Energy's Weatherization Assistance Program gives money to states to distribute to local governments, community action agencies, and nonprofits, who use the money to assist low-income homeowners or renters in reducing their energy costs. If you are approved, an inspector will conduct an energy audit, which involves checking your home for heat loss and safety features. If the audit shows that your home could benefit, a work crew will come to add insulation, plug leaks, improve dryer vents, install weather-stripping, etc. There is a limit to how much can be spent on each home, but everything that is done is free. This is a great opportunity for lower-income households to reduce their heating bills and improve the safety in their homes. To learn how to apply, visit: <https://www.energy.gov/eere/wap/how-apply-weatherization-assistance>

Community Resources:

Mutual aid funds: can address a variety of needs such as emergency rental assistance, medical bills, cash bail, or food. Mutual aid funds are a pool of donations by and for community members in which the money goes directly to those in immediate need.

- **Free fridges & pantries:** Another example of mutual aid, many communities are building and stocking free pantries and refrigerators. The idea is to leave food and other resources if you can and take what you need. Many schools, charities, churches, and shelters also have food pantries and food assistance programs.
- **Farmer's markets:** Many farmers markets now accept SNAP cards, which means you can get local and farm-fresh food for free or reduced prices.
- **Second-hand stores:** If you need clothing, shoes, or household items, second hand and thrift stores are usually the most budget-friendly way to shop. Some stores will also allow you to sell old clothes or give you in-store credit or discounts for donating items.
- **Community Credit Unions:** Credit unions are nonprofits that can help save you money when you bank with them by offering little-to-no fees and higher interest on savings.
- **Community Development Financial Institutions (CDFI):** Community-based financial institutions that promote economic development by providing services to low-income communities and other groups traditionally under-served by banking institutions. For a list of CDFIs in Oregon, visit: <https://www.cdfi.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/02/Oregon.pdf>
- **The Buy Nothing Project:** a money-less economy in which neighbors can post anything they'd like to give away, lend, or share, and ask for anything they'd like to receive or borrow. Join a Buy Nothing Group on Facebook or download the Buy Nothing app. For more information, visit <https://buynothingproject.org/join/>
- **Useful websites to identify resources:** <http://www.wisebread.com/resources> & <https://www.211info.org/search-resources>

If you are a resident of Oregon:

- Find reduced-cost or free community resources in the Portland Metro Area at <https://rosecityresource.streetroots.org/#/>
- Find free food in your community by typing in your Zip Code at www.oregonfoodbank.org
- If in Portland, find free fridges near you at <https://linktr.ee/pdxfreefridge>
- Find emergency rental assistance programs at <https://www.oregon.gov/ohcs/housing-assistance/Documents/05-13-2021-OERAP-program-admin-contact.pdf>

- For energy and weatherization services, youth services, housing support, nutrition services, and re-entry services in the Salem area, visit <https://mwvcaa.org/programs/>
- Get your movies and books at your local library: <https://multcolib.org/e-books-and-more>
- Find discounts and coupons in Portland at <https://portlandlivingonthecheap.com/>
- For Head Start programs in Oregon, visit <https://www.ohsa.net/>
- For home energy assistance, visit <https://www.oregon.gov/ohcs/energy-weatherization/pages/index.aspx>
- Great meals in Portland for less than \$10:
https://www.oregonlive.com/portland_cheap_eats/2017/03/cheap_eats_2017_99_delicious_d.html
- Fun activities to do in Portland on a budget:
https://www.oregonlive.com/living/2015/08/free_for_all_favorite_no-cost.html
<https://www.frugallivingnw.com/portland-staycation/>
- Portland Farmers Markets: <https://www.portlandfarmersmarket.org/>
- Oregon Farmers Markets that participate in Double Up Food Bucks (the SNAP dollars you spend at a Farmers market double, so you can buy more): <https://doubleuporegon.org/>
- To find clothing swaps in Portland, visit <https://swappositive.wordpress.com/>
- Biketown for All: Portland residents who are eligible for social services can receive a reduced Biketown Membership (city bikes available to the public). For more details, visit: <https://www.biketownpdx.com/pricing/biketown-for-all>

Applying for Social Security Benefits:

Some individuals experiencing mental health and/or addiction challenges find that there are times when working becomes too difficult. Social Security Disability Insurance Benefits (SSDI) and Supplemental Security Income (SSI) are programs by the Social Security Administration (SSA) that provide monthly income and health insurance for people with qualifying conditions, which can include severe depression, bipolar disorder, PTSD, anxiety disorders, or SUD, as detailed in the SSA Blue Book.⁴¹ The SSA has strict guidelines for qualifying for these programs that can be difficult to navigate. Generally, an individual needs to have detailed medical documentation that shows how their condition prevents them from working and that they are undergoing treatment.

⁴¹ "Mental Disorders and Social Security Disability." *Disability Benefits Help*, 2022 <https://www.disability-benefits-help.org/disabling-conditions/mental-disorders>

To qualify for SSDI, you must have an impairment that prevents you from working for at least 12 months and you must have worked and paid into the Social Security program (payroll taxes or FICA) for at least five of the last ten years. Your spouse and children can receive your SSDI benefits and after 24 months on SSDI, you are eligible for Medicare benefits. You may also be eligible to receive Supplemental Security Income (SSI) benefits.

To qualify for SSI, you must have an impairment that prevents you from working on a regular basis *and* you must have very low income, resources, and assets. An individual cannot have more than \$2,000 in assets (\$3,000 for couples). There are some exceptions, such as your home and car. In addition to federal benefits, you may also receive monthly payments from your state. You are eligible for Medicaid coverage and may be eligible for SSDI benefits at the same time if you have paid your Social Security taxes.⁴² SSI is a need-based program only available to applicants that meet strict limitations on income and asset holdings.

It can be helpful to consult with your doctor, therapist, mentor, or trusted friend or family member to help you navigate these criteria and gather all of the required information to apply for benefits. This will include all of your medical records, from hospitalization to therapist sessions, your doctor or psychologist's recommendation, and a list of all medications you are on and any side effects. You can apply for SSDI or SSI online at <https://www.ssa.gov/>, over the phone, or at your local Social Security office. If you are approved, your case will be reviewed every year.

If you decide to return to work, the SSA has a program called "Ticket to Work" that provides resources and assistance. A Benefits Counselor can help you to identify employment opportunities, discuss how returning to work will affect your SSDI or SSI benefits, and connect you to resources outside of the SSA. Visit <https://www.ssa.gov/work/> for more information.

⁴² "Social Security Disability Insurance Benefits & Supplemental Security Income." *National Alliance on Mental Illness* <https://www.mhamd.org/information-and-help/paying-for-care/applying-for-disability-benefits-with-a-mental-illness/>